

Pernis apivorus

European honey buzzard



Location Europe, W. and C. Asia, Africa

Length 20½–23½ in (52–60 cm)

Weight 16–36 oz (450–1,000 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Migrant

Status Least concern



Compared to similarly sized birds of prey, the European honey buzzard has small feet, relatively undeveloped talons, and a shallow, curved bill. This reflects its unusual lifestyle as a predator of wasps and other insects. It catches its food in midair, and also

follows insects back to their nests, to feed on their developing grubs. Because it depends on insects, it has to migrate southward in winter.

*Rostrhamus sociabilis*

Snail kite



Location S.E. USA (Florida), Cuba, Central America, South America



Length 16–18 in (40–45 cm)

Weight 13–14 oz (350–400 g)

Plumage Sexes differ

Migration Partial migrant

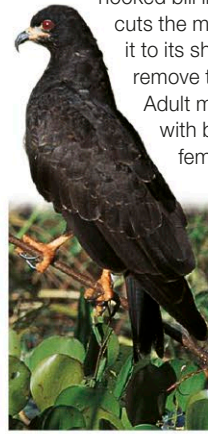
Status Least concern

Formerly called the Everglades kite, this bird is a specialist feeder on aquatic snails. It flies slowly over shallow marshland, snatching up surface-feeding

snails. It inserts its fine, heavily curved, hooked bill into the snail and cuts the muscle that attaches it to its shell, allowing it to remove the animal's body.

Adult males are dark gray with black primaries; females are brown

with streaked buff underparts. Rare in its south Florida range, it can be abundant elsewhere, as on the Argentine pampas.

*Milvus milvus*

Red kite



Location Europe, W. Asia, N. Africa, Canary and Cape Verde islands



Length 24–26 in (61–66 cm)

Weight 27–36 lb (750–1,000 g)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Near threatened

Kites are agile fliers, typically with long legs and forked tails. The red kite is the largest species, feeding mainly on small mammals, carrion, and young birds. It

flies with its wings partly bent, and uses its tail like a rudder, constantly tilting it as it searches for food. Two centuries ago, the red kite was a common scavenger in European towns and cities, but improved garbage disposal has made it much less common. It nests in trees, often using old nests of crows, laying 2–3 eggs each year.

*Gypaetus barbatus*

Bearded vulture



Location Europe, Asia, N., E., and southern Africa



Length 3¼–4 ft (1–1.2 m)

Weight 10–15 lb (4.5–7 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Near threatened

The bearded vulture is one of the largest Old World vultures, with huge wings, a conspicuous wedge-shaped tail, and distinctive beardlike feathers at the base of its bill. It eats carrion, but it also specializes at feeding on bones, carrying large ones high into the air and then dropping them onto rocks below. Once the bones have shattered, the bearded vulture lands to feed on the marrow inside.

*Neophron percnopterus*

Egyptian vulture



Location Europe, Africa, Asia



Length 23–28 in (58–70 cm)

Weight 3¼–4½ lb (1.5–2 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Partial migrant

Status Endangered

The smallest Old World vulture is now endangered because of pollution and decline of large ungulates. Adults have yellow faces and off-white plumage, apart from their black flight feathers; juveniles are speckled brown (shown here). Egyptian vultures scavenge all kinds of food, but are renowned for using stones to break open the eggs of ostriches and other birds.

Because of their small size, they have difficulty competing with other vultures at carcasses, and are often the last to feed.

*Gyps africanus*

White-backed vulture



Location Africa (south of Sahara)

Length 37 in (94 cm)

Weight 8¾–15 lb (4–7 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

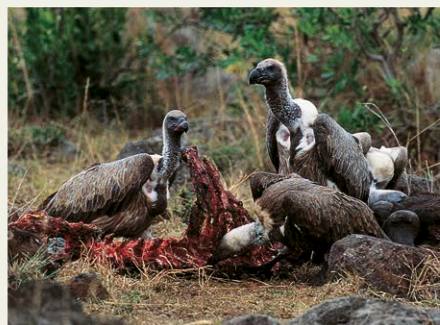
Status Critically endangered



This widespread African scavenger is a griffon vulture—one of a group of 8 species that have long necks that appear to be bald, but that are actually covered in fine down. This absence of large neck feathers allows griffon vultures to reach deep into carcasses without becoming soiled. They make a variety of hissing and cackling sounds as they jostle for a chance to eat. The white-backed vulture gets its name from a collar of white feathers at the top of its back, which contrasts with its gray neck. This species is one of Africa's most common vultures, but is severely threatened by both accidental and deliberate poisoning, which kills hundreds at one go.

FEEDING

White-backed vultures are legendary for their ability to find food. They have a poor sense of smell, but extremely good eyesight, enabling them to spot dead remains from high in the air. Vultures also keep an eye on each other. If one bird sees food and makes a sudden descent, others quickly follow suit.



LARGE WINGS

The large, broad wings of the white-backed vulture enable it to soar and circle on thermals for hours, looking for carrion.